

The Idea: Buddy

Buddy is a web-based social coordination app that helps users discover, join, and host in-person group activities based on their calendar availability, location, and interests. The app syncs with a user's calendar to identify free time and recommends relevant nearby events that fit their schedule. Users can also create events, invite friends, view mutual availability, and activate an "I'm Free" mode to find spontaneous things to do. A badge system rewards social participation, consistency, and helpfulness.

Similar Services & Why Buddy is Different

Existing Service	What it does	Why buddy is different
Google Calendar	Time-based scheduling with no social layer	Buddy adds location, social discovery, and spontaneity
Meetup	Formal, topic-based group events	Buddy focuses on spontaneous, personal, local activities
Facebook Events	Event hosting & invites	Buddy is time-aware and calendar-driven
Nextdoor	Hyperlocal neighborhood platform	Buddy is built for <i>action</i> , not just information
Snapchat / Friender	Social connections via chat or swiping	Buddy emphasizes shared <i>time + purpose</i>

Why Buddy is Possible Now

- **API maturity:** Calendar, Maps, and Notifications APIs are now widely available and reliable.
- **Increased loneliness & post-COVID social reawakening:** People want to reconnect, but friction makes it hard.
- **Cultural shift toward intentional time use:** Students and young professionals want to make better use of free time.
- **Ubiquity of mobile & location services:** Real-time data makes context-aware recommendations possible.

Stakeholder List

Stakeholder Type	Description	Values / Motivations / Expected Behavior
Users	Students, young professionals	Want meaningful connection and low-friction coordination. Use Buddy to find or host in-person events based on availability.
Customers	Local businesses, student orgs, universities	Want meaningful connection and low-friction coordination. Use Buddy to find or host in-person events based on availability.
Regulators	Data privacy (e.g., GDPR, CCPA)	Expect transparency, opt-ins for calendar and location. Compliant handling of user data.
Investors	Angels, accelerators, early-stage funds	Want scalable growth, strong user retention, unique engagement model. Look for defensibility and real market need.
Owners	Founders and early team	Want to create a product that makes social life easier and more meaningful. Balancing vision, usability, and monetization.
Employees	Developers, designers, community leads	Want mission alignment and meaningful contribution. Build features, shape user experience, and grow adoption
Others	Nonprofits, wellness groups	Use Buddy to drive participation in good causes. Value ease of outreach and volunteer engagement

User Journey: Primary User (College Student)

Name: Alex

Persona: Harvard undergrad, sophomore, studies computer science. Feels socially isolated between intense classwork and club commitments. Wants to do more spontaneous, low-pressure social things but often doesn't know what's happening when he's free.

Journey:

1. **Sunday night:** Alex syncs his Google Calendar to Buddy. He sets preferences: interests (food, music, volunteering), location radius (1.5 miles), and free time (after 6pm on weekdays).
2. **Monday 5:30 PM:** Alex taps "I'm Free." Buddy suggests a cooking night study break at Lowell in 30 minutes. He RSVPs and walks over.
3. **During the event:** Alex meets three new people, cooks, laughs, and earns the "First Stepper" and "Community Chef" badges.
4. **Later that week:** He sees mutual availability with a classmate, and they both join a study group suggested by Buddy.

Values Tensions:

- **Alex vs. University (customer):** The university/club organisers may want to track participation, but Alex expects privacy. Resolution: Buddy uses anonymized engagement stats.
- **Alex vs. Hosts:** Some events may be low-quality or bait for promotions. Resolution: Hosts are rated, and Buddy prioritizes trusted organizers.
- **Alex vs. Buddy (owners):** He values spontaneity; the app might push too many scheduled events. Resolution: Maintain balance between discovery and control.